

MEMBER GUIDES · C2

The New Brother’s Guide

For the newly initiated Brother: what happened, what happens next, who is who, and who is in your corner.

For	Entered Apprentices, given after Initiation
Issue	Issue 1a (Draft for Review), October 2026: the July 2026 text set on the Provincial template

HERTFORDSHIRE FREEMASONS

The New Brother's Guide

For the newly Initiated Entered Apprentice - your first year in Freemasonry

Prepare • Guide • Support • Enlighten

Issue 1 (Draft for Review)

July 2026

A Hertfordshire companion to the UGLE Initiate's Guide

Congratulations - and Breathe

You are now a Freemason: a member of the oldest and most widespread fraternal organisation in the world, part of a tradition that was meeting for centuries before you were born and will be meeting long after all of us. Last night (or recently), you experienced something few people in the modern world ever do.

And you probably have no idea what most of it meant. Good. That is exactly how it is supposed to feel. Nobody - nobody - walks out of their Initiation with a clear understanding of what has just happened. The ceremony is designed to be experienced first and understood gradually, over years, in layers. Your questions are not a sign that you missed something; they are the point. The entire structure of Freemasonry exists to help you answer them, at your own pace.

This guide is the Hertfordshire companion to the UGLE Initiate's Guide you have been given. That book explains the Craft nationally; this one tells you how things work here, who is who, and what your first year is likely to feel like - honestly.

The Two Feelings - Both Normal

Some new Brothers feel overwhelmed. The ceremony was intense and mysterious; at the meal afterwards everyone seemed fluent in a language you don't yet speak. If that is you: relax. Every man in that room once stood where you stand, and most of them remember it vividly. You are not expected to know anything yet. Ask your mentor anything - there are no stupid questions, and the Brother who asks is always thought better of, never worse.

Some new Brothers feel underwhelmed - and nobody warns them about this one, so we will. After the drama of your Initiation, your second meeting may be ordinary business. Your first rehearsal evening may have little in it for you. There will be meetings where you must wait outside for part of the evening (more below). This is not Freemasonry failing you; it is the ordinary rhythm of Lodge life, and the treasures are unevenly spaced. Tell your mentor honestly when an evening falls flat - managing that, together, is precisely what he is for.

Who's Who - Your Support

Person	What they are to you
Your Personal Mentor	Your guide and friend. He will meet you one-to-one soon after your Initiation, prepare you before every new experience, and is your first call for any question, however small, at any time. If you take nothing else from this guide: use him. He volunteered because he wants to be used.
Your Proposer and Seconder	The members who brought you in. They remain your sponsors and will always take an interest.
The Lodge Mentor	Co-ordinates the support of all new members across the Lodge.
The Worshipful Master (WM)	The Lodge's presiding officer, elected annually. You will see him in the Chair; he initiated you.
The Secretary and Treasurer	Administration and money. The Secretary sends the summons (the formal meeting notice); reply to it promptly - including your dining choice - and send apologies if you cannot attend.

The Almoner	The Lodge's welfare officer - for you and your family, in illness, difficulty or bereavement. Freemasons look after their own; the Almoner is how.
The Director of Ceremonies (DC)	Runs the ceremonial side of meetings. If you are ever unsure where to stand or what to do, follow the DC's lead - that is what everyone else does.
The Tyler	Guards the door - and looks after anyone waiting outside it. You met him on your big night; he is often the friendliest man in the building.

Your First Year - What Actually Happens

- **Meetings.** Arrive early - thirty minutes is about right. Late is better than never, but early means company, introductions and no rush. Your mentor or another Brother will sit with you.
- **Waiting outside.** As an Entered Apprentice there are parts of some meetings - when the Lodge works in a 'higher degree' you have not yet taken - that you cannot yet attend. You will be asked to retire, and an experienced Brother will keep you company. This is not exclusion; it is sequence. Everything you are waiting for, you will see - from the best seat in the house, when your turn comes. Many Lodges use this time for exactly what it is good for: your questions.
- **The test questions.** Before your Second Degree you will learn the answers to a short set of traditional questions, and answer them in open Lodge. Your mentor will rehearse them with you until you are comfortable - and you go when you are ready, not when the calendar says. Everyone finds it daunting; everyone survives; and the moment after you answer is one of the best in your early Masonic life.
- **The Lodge of Instruction (LoI).** The Lodge's rehearsal evening - relaxed, informal, mistakes and laughter included. It is where ceremonies are polished, friendships deepen fastest, and confidence is built. Go when you can; there is no obligation to perform anything. Ask your mentor when and where it meets.
- **The Festive Board.** The meal after the meeting - and not an afterthought: for many members it is the heart of the evening. Toasts follow a traditional order, and there is a rhythmic tradition of 'fire' after some of them that your mentor will show you before you ever need to join in. Sit with different people as the months pass; the room is full of interesting lives.

- **Dress.** Dark suit, white shirt, black shoes; the Lodge will tell you its tie custom. Your apron - which you will wear at every meeting - was explained on the night you received it: it is the badge of a Freemason, and older than most orders of chivalry.

Learning - at Your Pace, Led by Your Curiosity

- **Solomon** (solomon.ugle.org.uk) is UGLE's online learning platform and the reliable place for answers - accurate, official, and written for members. Register early; explore freely. One gentle rule: leave material about ceremonies you have not yet experienced until afterwards - for the same reason you wouldn't read the last page of a novel first.
- **DAWG - the Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group** - run by the Provincial Mentoring Team, delivers a two-minute piece of Masonic learning to your phone each day. One of a Freemason's oldest obligations is 'a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge'; this makes it achievable over a morning coffee. Ask your mentor to add you.
- **The internet at large:** treat with care. Much online material about Freemasonry is inaccurate, foreign to our tradition, or simply invented. When in doubt: Solomon, this Province's website, or your mentor.
- **Visiting other Lodges** is one of Freemasonry's best pleasures, and you don't have to wait long for it. Watching a ceremony you have been through, from a comfortable seat, is when the pieces start to fit. Your mentor will take you.

The Wider World You Have Joined

Your Lodge belongs to the Province of Hertfordshire - more than a hundred and fifty Lodges under a Provincial Grand Master - which in turn belongs to the United Grand Lodge of England. Practically, this means: events across the county, from formal meetings to family days; a Provincial team whose job includes looking after you; and thousands of Hertfordshire Brethren you have not met yet.

If you are one of the younger men in your Lodge, note the Fleet House Light Blues Club (FHLBC) - Hertfordshire's club for newer and younger Masons, built on a simple principle: no one left in the corner. It exists so that a man can love the tradition of his own Lodge and still find Brothers of his own age and outlook across the Province. Ask your mentor to put you in touch.

In time - and entirely at your own pace - you will hear about the Royal Arch, which UGLE describes as the completion of the journey you have just begun. There is

nothing to decide now, and no one will pressure you, ever. When you are curious, ask; you will get information, not a sales pitch.

Family, Work, Masonry - In That Order, Always

You will hear this said in Hertfordshire, and it is meant. If work explodes, if family needs you, if life shifts - your Lodge will still be here, and the only right response from your Brethren is 'How can we help?' Never feel you must choose between Freemasonry and the people who matter most; Freemasonry's own teaching is that they come first. Tell your mentor when life is heavy. That is not letting the Lodge down; it is exactly the kind of honesty the relationship is built for.

And one more thing: it is meant to be fun. If you leave a meeting feeling better than when you arrived - richer for the company, the ceremony and the laughter - Freemasonry is working. If ever it stops feeling that way, say so. That conversation is one your mentor genuinely wants to have.

Quick Reference

- Any question, any time → your Personal Mentor.
- Can't attend a meeting → apologies to the Secretary (and reply to every summons promptly).
- Illness or difficulty at home → the Almoner, in complete confidence.
- Reliable learning → Solomon (solomon.ugle.org.uk), DAWG, www.pgherts.org.
- Company your own age → Fleet House Light Blues Club, via your mentor.

Welcome, Brother. We are genuinely glad you are here - and you will never walk alone.

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